excited Gandhi informed Ratan about their victory and the chairman was ‘thrilled and was very happy’. He ‘thanked me profusely’, recalls Gandhi. Tata Steel had won the bid at 608p a share, which represented a 5p difference between the winning and the second-highest bid as mandated by the extant rules.

‘Within half an hour, champagne corks were popping,’ wrote *The Times.* The cost of the acquisition was $12.1 billion or £6.2 billion. The Tata veterans had quoted well. It was a fair price, says Chatterjee. If at all, ‘we paid less’, he says. With Corus’s EBITDA at £1 billion, the price should have been higher, he asserts.

Not everyone agreed with him, though. Comparisons were also drawn with what steel tycoon Lakshmi Niwas Mittal had paid for the Luxembourg-based Arcelor just a year ago—only 4.5 times its earnings. On the other hand, Corus had cost nine times its earnings. In addition, it was an all-cash deal. It had no equity component, which Mittal’s acquisition had.

The Independent commented, ‘Mr Tata seems to have forgotten the extreme cyclicality of Corus’s history, where the company would be riding high one moment and be on the verge of bankruptcy the next. This is not a business which can safely take on so much debt.’ The newspaper went on to add that although Tata Steel was in it for the long haul, the short term might play spoilsport: ‘India’s “moment of fulfilment” may yet become Tata’s nemesis.’ *The Wall Street Journal* also carried a similar story.

The team was, nevertheless, exuberant, says Muthuraman. Soon, it put out a press release that Ratan had approved hours before, hoping that they would win the bid. He recalls that the chairman had asked him to prepare another one in the event that they lost. Muthuraman had prepared three versions of the second press release, but none passed muster with the chairman. He now insinuates that the failure of the second version to get approval three times over was a divine sign that Tata Steel was destined to triumph.

The cliffhanger contest was not easy for Ratan. Recollecting the tense moments of those early hours of 31 January, he told a leading newspaper, ‘We didn’t have an indication of which way the bidding was headed. As the night went on, it became onerous because we were confined to follow the schedule dictated by the Takeover Panel.’ The negotiation-turned-bidding war for Corus, however, sent the Western world into a tizzy, as it was surprised by Ratan’s extraordinary aggressiveness.